

Mass

Main service of the Roman Catholic Church.

Measure

A segment of time containing a fixed number of beats. Also called a bar.

medley

An arrangement of several different compositions run together as one piece.

melody

A series of notes that create a tune or theme.

meter

A recurring, rhythmic pattern of stressed and unstressed beats.

mezzo-soprano

The lowest soprano voice.

minimalism

A modern musical style based on repeated short patterns.

minor

The term minor can be applied to a key signature, or chord, triad, or scale in a minor key. Music in a minor key is said to sound dark or sad. Minor intervals are a half step smaller than major intervals.

minuet and trio

A graceful dance in 3/4 time, normally in three sections.

modes

Seven-note scales, commonly used in the Middle Ages and in folk music.

modulation

A shift from one key to another.

monody

A single, unaccompanied melodic line.

mordent

An ornament similar to a trill.

motet

A highly varied choral composition usually without instrumental accompaniment.

motif

A recurring figure, often used to refer to a character or idea.

movement

A self-contained section of a larger work.

musicology

The academic study of music.

mute

A device that reduces the volume or changes the tone of an instrument.

natural

A note that is not sharp or flat. The symbol that cancels sharps and flats.

notation

The symbols used to represent a piece of music visually.

note values

The duration of a note—how long it should be played.

octave

The interval between one pitch and another with double or half its frequency—for example, between the notes C and C on a keyboard.

octet

A group of eight singers or musicians.

ondes martenot

An early electronic keyboard instrument.

opera

Drama in which the characters sing, usually written for full orchestra, soloists, and chorus.

operetta

A light opera, often including some spoken dialogue.

opus

A Latin word meaning “work,” often abbreviated “op.” and used with a number to catalog a composer’s pieces.

oratorio

A sacred work for voices and instrumental accompaniment.

orchestra

A large ensemble, with players divided into strings, woodwind, brass, and percussion.

orchestration

The art of writing for an orchestra.

ornament

An embellishment of a note or chord.

overtone

Part of the harmonic series of a single note.

overture

An instrumental introduction to an opera or ballet.

part-song

An unaccompanied song for two or more voices.

passage

Any section of a piece of music.

Passion music

A musical setting of the suffering of Jesus from the Last Supper to the Crucifixion.

pedal bass

A held note in the bass.

pentatonic scale

A scale of five notes.

phrase

A group of notes that form a unit of music.

pitch

The position of a sound in relation to the whole range of tonal sounds.

pizzicato

A style of playing stringed instruments that are usually played with a bow, by plucking the strings with the fingers.

plainsong

Medieval church music, also known as plainchant.

polyphony

A style of writing in classical music in which all parts are of equal importance.

prelude

An introductory piece of music.

principal

The lead musician in a section of the orchestra, responsible for leading the group and playing any solos.

program music

Music written to tell a story, or describe a scene using sound.

progression

The transition from one note to the next.

quartet

A group of four instruments or voices.

quodlibet

The combination of two or more folk tunes in counterpoint.

range

The range of an instrument or voice is the distance from the lowest to the highest pitch it can play or sing.

recital

A performance of classical music by a soloist or small group.

recitative

Style of singing in opera and oratorio that uses the rhythm of ordinary speech and is used for dialogue.

reed

A thin piece of wood, metal, or plastic that is attached to the mouthpiece of a woodwind instrument and vibrates to produce a sound.

reed

A fast-paced dance tune common in Irish and Scottish folk music.